SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #21 · MEDIA AND SOCIAL MEDIA

“Everyone else's life is better than mine.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Social media shows other people’s best moments: vacations, new homes, engagements, promotions, happy kids. We compare those highlights to our own full, ordinary days. The longer we scroll, the more our life seems lacking, and envy and discouragement grow.

What Scripture teaches

Solomon observed, “All labor and success spring from a man’s envy of his neighbor. This too is futile and a pursuit of the wind.” Proverbs says, “A tranquil heart is life to the body, but envy rots the bones.” Paul writes, “Each one should test his own work. Then he will have reason to boast in himself alone, and not in someone else,” and “Let us not become conceited, provoking and envying one another.” He also says, “I have learned to be content” in plenty and in need. Comparison steals contentment. Gratitude and honest self-examination restore it.

> *“Each one should test his own work. Then he will have reason to boast in himself alone, and not in someone else”* (Galatians 6:4).

Also see

> “A tranquil heart is life to the body, but envy rots the bones” (Proverbs 14:30).

> “I saw that all labor and success spring from a man’s envy of his neighbor. This too is futile and a pursuit of the wind” (Ecclesiastes 4:4).

> “Let us not become conceited, provoking and envying one another” (Galatians 5:26).

> “I know how to live humbly, and I know how to abound. I am accustomed to any and every situation—to being filled and being hungry, to having plenty and having need. I can do all things through Christ who gives me strength” (Philippians 4:12–13).

Common self-statements

- Everyone else is happier than I am.
- I am falling behind.
- My life is boring and small.
- They have it all together.
- I am missing out.
- What is wrong with my life?

Common logical errors

- Social comparison: Comparing my whole life with others’ highlights.
- Mental filter: Focusing on what I lack.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing others’ lives are perfect and mine is not.
- Discounting the positive: Overlooking blessings in my own life.

Challenging questions

- What am I actually seeing online, and what am I not seeing?

- How do I feel after scrolling?
- What good things do I have that do not show up in photos?
- What would I think of my life if I could not compare?
- What does Scripture say about envy and contentment?
- What limits on social media would help?

Truth summary

> Online lives are curated. My life has real struggles and real blessings, and God has given me my own path. I can limit comparison, give thanks, and invest in the life in front of me.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Envy/Jealousy
- Thankful
- Dissatisfaction
- Joy
- Thinking, Healthy

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Thinking, Healthy
- Pride

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Already There — Casting Crowns
God's perspective extends beyond what we can currently understand.

Thrive — Casting Crowns
Life rooted in God includes purposeful growth and joy, not merely surviving or staying busy.

If We Are the Body — Casting Crowns
The church is called to welcome and care for people rather than exclude or shame them.

Great Is Thy Faithfulness — CeCe Winans
This classic hymn recalls God's steady mercy through changing circumstances.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Everyone else's life is better than mine"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Everyone else's life is better than mine." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What am I not seeing online?
- ☐ How do I feel after scrolling?
- ☐ What am I thankful for?
- ☐ What limit would help?
- ☐ Who can I see in person?
- ☐ What is good in my life?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I do not see the whole picture online.
- ☐ Envy rots; a tranquil heart gives life.
- ☐ I can test my own work and not compare.
- ☐ Contentment can be learned.
- ☐ I have blessings I overlook.
- ☐ I can limit what feeds comparison.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Galatians 6:4**
  "Each one should test his own work. Then he will have reason to boast in himself alone, and not in someone else."
- ☐ **Proverbs 14:30**
  "A tranquil heart is life to the body, but envy rots the bones."
- ☐ **Philippians 4:12–13**
  "I know how to live humbly, and I know how to abound. I am accustomed to any and every situation—to being filled and being hungry, to having plenty and having need. I can do all things through Christ who gives me strength."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Thankful instead of comparing: Each day, write three things you are thankful for in your own life.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Galatians 6:4 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I can test my own work and not compare myself to others.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Envy/Jealousy" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Track how you feel. Note your mood before and after scrolling.
- [ ] Set limits. Reduce time or unfollow accounts that trigger comparison.
- [ ] Write a gratitude list. Name ten blessings that do not appear on screen.
- [ ] Reach out in person. Connect with a friend face to face.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Everyone else's life is better than mine": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Thankful, not comparing
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Everyone else's life is better than mine.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I compare my life to highlights and feel small. Teach me contentment, show me my own blessings, and help me live fully in the life You gave me. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #22 · MEDIA AND SOCIAL MEDIA

“If I'm not liked online, I don't matter.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Likes, followers, shares, and comments feel like measures of worth, and they trigger the brain’s reward systems. Young people especially can tie self-esteem to numbers. A post with few responses can feel like rejection, and silence can feel like being forgotten.

What Scripture teaches

Paul asks, “Am I now seeking the approval of men, or of God?” Proverbs says, “The fear of man is a snare, but whoever trusts in the LORD is set securely on high.” The psalmist says, “I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made,” and God declares, “The LORD your God is among you… He will rejoice over you with gladness.” God told Samuel, “Man sees the outward appearance, but the LORD sees the heart.” Our worth was set at creation and sealed at the cross, and no number of likes can raise or lower it.

> *“Am I now seeking the approval of men, or of God? Or am I striving to please men? If I were still trying to please men, I would not be a servant of Christ”* (Galatians 1:10).

Also see

> “The fear of man is a snare, but whoever trusts in the LORD is set securely on high” (Proverbs 29:25).

> “For You formed my inmost being; You knit me together in my mother’s womb. I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Marvelous are Your works, and I know this very well” (Psalm 139:13–14).

> “The LORD your God is among you; He is mighty to save. He will rejoice over you with gladness; He will quiet you with His love; He will rejoice over you with singing” (Zephaniah 3:17).

> “But the LORD said to Samuel, ‘Do not consider his appearance or height, for I have rejected him; the LORD does not see as man does. For man sees the outward appearance, but the LORD sees the heart.’” (1 Samuel 16:7).

Common self-statements

- No likes means no one cares.
- My worth is my follower count.
- If it flops, I flopped.
- I have to post to be seen.
- People who matter get attention.
- I am invisible without engagement.

Common logical errors

- Emotional reasoning: Feeling ignored and concluding I do not matter.
- Mind reading: Assuming silence means disapproval.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I am either popular or worthless.
- Labeling: Measuring myself by a number.

Challenging questions

- What do I hope likes will give me?

- How do I feel when a post gets little response?
- Who in real life values me, regardless of a screen?
- What does God say about my worth?
- What would change if I posted without checking numbers?
- What offline activity could remind me of my value?

Truth summary

> Likes measure attention, not worth. God made me, loves me, and delights in me. I can use social media without letting it decide who I am.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Pride
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Worldly
- Fear
- Love, By God

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Pride

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

You Say — Lauren Daigle
God's loving assessment challenges identity based only on weakness or feelings.

Who Am I — Casting Crowns
Being known and cared for by God rests on His love rather than personal importance.

Voice of Truth — Casting Crowns
Test accusing or frightening messages against God's truth.

Jesus Loves Me — Gaither Vocal Band
This familiar hymn places confidence in Jesus' love rather than personal strength.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

My Plan for Replacing "If I'm not liked online, I don't matter"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"If I'm not liked online, I don't matter." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What do I hope likes give me?
- ☐ How do I feel when posts flop?
- ☐ Who values me in person?
- ☐ What does God say?
- ☐ What if I did not check numbers?
- ☐ What offline thing helps?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ My worth is not a number.
- ☐ I seek God's approval first.
- ☐ The fear of man is a snare.
- ☐ God delights in me.
- ☐ Real people value me.
- ☐ I can post without needing applause.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Galatians 1:10**
  "Am I now seeking the approval of men, or of God? Or am I striving to please men? If I were still trying to please men, I would not be a servant of Christ."
- ☐ **Psalm 139:13–14**
  "For You formed my inmost being; You knit me together in my mother's womb. I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Marvelous are Your works, and I know this very well."
- ☐ **Zephaniah 3:17**
  "The LORD your God is among you; He is mighty to save. He will rejoice over you with gladness; He will quiet you with His love; He will rejoice over you with singing."

A verse I found myself: _____

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Worth beyond numbers: Each day, note one person who values you in real life.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.
  For example, Zephaniah 3:17 becomes: "Sarah can write: "The Lord rejoices over me, whatever the numbers say.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Self-Esteem, Low" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- ☐ Take a break. Go offline for a day or weekend.
- ☐ Hide the counts. Turn off like counts if possible.
- ☐ Invest in people. Spend time face to face with those who love you.
- ☐ Memorize Zephaniah 3:17. Say it when you check the numbers.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "If I'm not liked online, I don't matter": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Worth beyond numbers
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~If I'm not liked online, I don't matter.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, I have looked to likes for worth. Remind me that You delight in me. Free me from the fear of man, and let me share without needing applause. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #23 · MEDIA AND SOCIAL MEDIA

"I must have the latest things to be happy."

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Advertising, influencers, and peers keep telling us that the next phone, car, outfit, or gadget will fill the gap. The excitement of a new purchase is real and short-lived, and then the desire resets. Debt and clutter can follow.

What Scripture teaches

Paul writes, "Godliness with contentment is great gain. For we brought nothing into the world, so we cannot carry anything out of it. But if we have food and clothing, we will be content with these." Jesus said, "Guard yourselves against every form of greed, for one's life does not consist in the abundance of his possessions." Solomon wrote, "He who loves money is never satisfied by money." The writer of Hebrews says, "Keep your lives free from the love of money and be content with what you have," because God has promised never to leave or forsake us. Lasting joy comes from the Giver, not the gadget.

> *"Of course, godliness with contentment is great gain. For we brought nothing into the world, so we cannot carry anything out of it. But if we have food and clothing, we will be content with these"* (1 Timothy 6:6–8).

Also see

> "Keep your lives free from the love of money and be content with what you have, for God has said: 'Never will I leave you, never will I forsake you.'" (Hebrews 13:5).

> "And He said to them, 'Watch out! Guard yourselves against every form of greed, for one's life does not consist in the abundance of his possessions.'" (Luke 12:15).

> "He who loves money is never satisfied by money, and he who loves wealth is never satisfied by income. This too is futile" (Ecclesiastes 5:10).

> "Do not store up for yourselves treasures on earth, where moth and rust destroy, and where thieves break in and steal. But store up for yourselves treasures in heaven, where moth and rust do not destroy, and where thieves do not break in and steal. For where your treasure is, there your heart will be also" (Matthew 6:19–21).

Common self-statements

- I will be happy once I get that.
- My old one is embarrassing.
- Everyone else has the new version.
- I deserve the upgrade.
- Without it I am falling behind.
- The next purchase will satisfy me.

Common logical errors

- Magical thinking: Believing a purchase will change how I feel for good.
- Social comparison: Measuring myself by what others own.
- Should statements: Insisting that I should have the latest.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling a want and treating it as a need.

Challenging questions

- How long did happiness last after my last big purchase?
- What emptiness am I hoping something will fill?
- What do I already have that I once longed for?
- How is my spending affecting my finances and peace?
- What does Scripture say about contentment?
- What would a 30-day pause before buying look like?

Truth summary

> Things cannot fill what only God can. Contentment is a learned gift that frees me from the treadmill. I can enjoy good things without needing the newest.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Dissatisfaction
- Greedy/Stingy
- Money
- Thankful
- Worldly

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Money/Riches
- Thinking, Healthy

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Already There — Casting Crowns
God's perspective extends beyond what we can currently understand.

Thrive — Casting Crowns
Life rooted in God includes purposeful growth and joy, not merely surviving or staying busy.

Forever — Kari Jobe
Christ's resurrection grounds hope in His victory over sin and death.

Great Is Thy Faithfulness — CeCe Winans
This classic hymn recalls God's steady mercy through changing circumstances.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I must have the latest things to be happy"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I must have the latest things to be happy." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ How long did happiness last?
- ☐ What emptiness am I filling?
- ☐ What do I already have?
- ☐ What is it costing me?
- ☐ What does contentment look like?
- ☐ What can I give away?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Godliness with contentment is great gain.
- ☐ Life is not the abundance of possessions.
- ☐ I already have what I once wanted.
- ☐ God will never leave me.
- ☐ Waiting before buying is wise.
- ☐ Joy comes from the Giver.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **1 Timothy 6:6–8**
  "Of course, godliness with contentment is great gain. For we brought nothing into the world, so we cannot carry anything out of it. But if we have food and clothing, we will be content with these."
- ☐ **Hebrews 13:5**
  "Keep your lives free from the love of money and be content with what you have, for God has said: 'Never will I leave you, never will I forsake you.'"
- ☐ **Luke 12:15**
  "And He said to them, 'Watch out! Guard yourselves against every form of greed, for one's life does not consist in the abundance of his possessions.'"

A verse I found myself: _____

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Enough: Each week, name one thing that is enough and one purchase you paused.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, 1 Timothy 6:6–8 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Godliness with contentment is great gain.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Dissatisfaction" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- ☐ Track the pattern. Write the last three purchases and how long the happiness lasted.
- ☐ Pause before buying. Wait 30 days on non-essentials.
- ☐ Give something away. Donate something you no longer need.
- ☐ Practice thanks. Thank God for one old possession each day.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I must have the latest things to be happy": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Enough
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I must have the latest things to be happy.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I chase the next thing. Teach me contentment, free me from the treadmill, and help me enjoy what I have and share it. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #24 · MEDIA AND SOCIAL MEDIA

“What the media says is normal must be right.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Television, streaming, music, news, and social media shape what feels ordinary: how people speak, treat each other, spend, relate, and think. Because we see it so often, it can seem like everyone does it and so it must be fine. Over time, we may adopt values without noticing.

What Scripture teaches

Paul writes, “Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind. Then you will be able to test and approve what is the good, pleasing, and perfect will of God.” Isaiah warns, “Woe to those who call evil good and good evil.” Proverbs says, “There is a way that seems right to a man, but its end is the way of death.” Philippians 4:8 gives a filter: “whatever is true, whatever is honorable, whatever is right, whatever is pure, whatever is lovely, whatever is admirable.” Common is not the same as right.

> *“Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind. Then you will be able to test and approve what is the good, pleasing, and perfect will of God”* (Romans 12:2).

Also see

> “Woe to those who call evil good and good evil, who turn darkness to light and light to darkness, who replace bitter with sweet and sweet with bitter” (Isaiah 5:20).

> “There is a way that seems right to a man, but its end is the way of death” (Proverbs 14:12).

> “Finally, brothers, whatever is true, whatever is honorable, whatever is right, whatever is pure, whatever is lovely, whatever is admirable—if anything is excellent or praiseworthy—think on these things” (Philippians 4:8).

> “Do not love the world or anything in the world. If anyone loves the world, the love of the Father is not in him. For all that is in the world—the desires of the flesh, the desires of the eyes, and the pride of life—is not from the Father but from the world. The world is passing away, along with its desires; but whoever does the will of God remains forever” (1 John 2:15–17).

Common self-statements

- Everyone does it, so it is fine.
- If it is on TV, it is normal.
- I do not need to question what I watch.
- That is just how people live now.
- Questioning it makes me old-fashioned.
- If it is everywhere, it must be acceptable.

Common logical errors

- Bandwagon thinking: Assuming that popular means right.
- Authority bias: Treating media as a moral authority.
- Normalization: Letting repetition reduce my sensitivity.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling comfortable and concluding that it is good.

Challenging questions

- What values does the media I consume promote?
- How have those messages shaped what I expect from relationships, money, or myself?
- What does Scripture say is true, honorable, and lovely?
- What would I think of this if I had never seen it on screen?
- How does my media diet affect my mood and faith?
- What would I change in what I watch or listen to?

Truth summary

> Popular is not the same as right. I can test what I see and hear against God's word, choose what I take in, and let my mind be renewed.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Worldly
- Thinking, Healthy
- Thinking, Unhealthy
- Wisdom
- Scripture/Word

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Thinking, Healthy
- Pride

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Truth Be Told — Matthew West featuring Carly Pearce
Honesty about struggles makes room for grace and support instead of pretending to be fine.

Fear Is a Liar — Zach Williams
Examine fear-driven accusations rather than treating them as reliable truth.

Voice of Truth — Casting Crowns
Test accusing or frightening messages against God's truth.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

My Plan for Replacing "What the media says is normal must be right"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"What the media says is normal must be right." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What values does my media promote?
- ☐ How have they shaped me?
- ☐ What is true and lovely?
- ☐ What would I change?
- ☐ Who can I talk with?
- ☐ What will I test this week?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I can test everything against God's word.
- ☐ Common is not right.
- ☐ A way that seems right can lead astray.
- ☐ I can think on what is true and lovely.
- ☐ My mind can be renewed.
- ☐ I choose what I take in.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Romans 12:2**
  "Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind. Then you will be able to test and approve what is the good, pleasing, and perfect will of God."
- ☐ **Philippians 4:8**
  "Finally, brothers, whatever is true, whatever is honorable, whatever is right, whatever is pure, whatever is lovely, whatever is admirable—if anything is excellent or praiseworthy—think on these things."
- ☐ **Proverbs 14:12**
  "There is a way that seems right to a man, but its end is the way of death."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Tested and chosen: Each week, note one message you tested against Scripture and one media change you made.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Romans 12:2 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I will be transformed by renewing my mind, not conformed to the world.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Worldly" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Audit your media. List what you watch, read, and listen to.
- [ ] Test one message. Compare it with Philippians 4:8.
- [ ] Make one change. Replace or reduce something that harms you.
- [ ] Discuss. Talk about it with a friend or family member.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "What the media says is normal must be right": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A message tested
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~What the media says is normal must be right.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, shape my mind with Your truth. Help me notice the messages I absorb, test them by Your word, and choose what is true, lovely, and good. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #25 · MEDIA AND SOCIAL MEDIA

“If it feels good, it must be okay.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Culture often says, “Follow your heart,” and “If it feels right, do it.” Feelings are real and important, but they are not reliable moral guides, especially when tired, hurt, tempted, or in a rush. This belief can lead to choices we later regret.

What Scripture teaches

Proverbs says, “There is a way that seems right to a man, but its end is the way of death.” “Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and lean not on your own understanding.” “Be not wise in your own eyes; fear the LORD and turn away from evil.” Paul says, “Pay careful attention, then, to how you walk, not as unwise but as wise.” Feelings are information. They tell us what we want or fear, but they are not the final word. Wisdom weighs feelings against God’s word and the long-term consequences.

> *“There is a way that seems right to a man, but its end is the way of death”* (Proverbs 14:12).

Also see

> “Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and lean not on your own understanding; in all your ways acknowledge Him, and He will make your paths straight” (Proverbs 3:5–6).

> “Be not wise in your own eyes; fear the LORD and turn away from evil” (Proverbs 3:7).

> “Pay careful attention, then, to how you walk, not as unwise but as wise, redeeming the time, because the days are evil” (Ephesians 5:15–16).

> “Finally, brothers, whatever is true, whatever is honorable, whatever is right, whatever is pure, whatever is lovely, whatever is admirable—if anything is excellent or praiseworthy—think on these things” (Philippians 4:8).

Common self-statements

- If it feels right, it is right.
- My feelings tell me what is true.
- I deserve to feel good.
- If no one is hurt, it is fine.
- I will not know until I try it.
- My heart cannot lead me wrong.

Common logical errors

- Emotional reasoning: Treating feelings as facts or moral guides.
- Short-term thinking: Ignoring consequences.
- Rationalization: Finding reasons to justify what I want.
- Minimizing: Assuming no one is hurt.

Challenging questions

- What is my feeling telling me, and what does it want?
- What are the likely consequences a month or a year from now?

- What does Scripture say about this choice?
- Who might be affected that I have not thought of?
- Whom could I ask for wise counsel?
- Have my feelings misled me before?

Truth summary

> Feelings are important signals but not the final guide. I can listen to them, then weigh them against God's word, wise counsel, and consequences. Wisdom often means choosing what is right when it does not feel best.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Wisdom
- Temptation
- Thinking, Unhealthy
- Guidance
- Will of God

Godly Counsel Lessons:

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- Thinking, Healthy
- Anxiety/Worry/Fear

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

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Songs that speak truth to this belief

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Honesty about struggles makes room for grace and support instead of pretending to be fine.

Voice of Truth — Casting Crowns
Test accusing or frightening messages against God's truth.

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "If it feels good, it must be okay"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"If it feels good, it must be okay." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What am I feeling?
- ☐ What are the consequences?
- ☐ What does Scripture say?
- ☐ Who is affected?
- ☐ Whom can I ask?
- ☐ Have feelings misled me?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Feelings are information, not authority.
- ☐ A way that seems right can lead astray.
- ☐ I can trust the Lord over my own understanding.
- ☐ Wisdom weighs consequences.
- ☐ Wise counsel protects me.
- ☐ I can choose what is right.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Proverbs 14:12**
  "There is a way that seems right to a man, but its end is the way of death."
- ☐ **Proverbs 3:5–6**
  "Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and lean not on your own understanding; in all your ways acknowledge Him, and He will make your paths straight."
- ☐ **Ephesians 5:15–16**
  "Pay careful attention, then, to how you walk, not as unwise but as wise, redeeming the time, because the days are evil."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

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- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
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  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Feeling and wisdom: Each week, note one decision where you weighed feelings against wisdom.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Proverbs 14:12 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I will trust the Lord over my own feelings and understanding.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Wisdom" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Name the feeling. Write what you feel and what it wants.
- [ ] Think ahead. Write likely outcomes in a week, month, and year.
- [ ] Check with Scripture. Look up relevant passages.
- [ ] Ask a wise friend. Get counsel before deciding.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "If it feels good, it must be okay": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Feeling and wisdom
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
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Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~If it feels good, it must be okay.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, my feelings are strong. Teach me to listen to them, but to trust You above them. Give me wisdom, wise counselors, and courage to choose what is right. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.